going to steal our show. He crashes 117 runs in 57 balls, and helps his team reach 205 for six in 20 overs. Are we really going to fall at the very first hurdle?

The first ball of our innings is a searing Daren Powell bouncer and it crashes into Graeme Smith's finger. He is hurt and the physio rushes to his side but, after swallowing a few painkillers, he carries on and continues his innings. He's not going anywhere. That's proper leadership, I say to myself. That's a fighting spirit.

Herschelle Gibbs emerges as our hero, thrilling the crowd with an array of drives and pulls, scoring 90 runs from just 55 balls, and powering us to our target with two overs to spare. More than 26 000 spectators go wild. I contribute 16 runs from nine balls, including a six and a four, a bit-part player again ...

Our place in the Super Eight has already been secured when we prepare to play Bangladesh at Newlands, but another win sustains our momentum and we progress to a group alongside India, England and New Zealand from which two teams will advance to the semifinals. Maybe this is our time.

We defeat England at Newlands as the outstanding Albie Morkel excels with bat and ball, and we overcome New Zealand at Kingsmead, with Justin Kemp scoring 89 and Morné Morkel taking four wickets. I score only 18 and then one in these two matches, but the team is winning and that is what matters. Amid a growing sense of excitement around the country, at last, everything seems to be going our way ...

It is our third and final Super Eight match and, still unbeaten in the tournament, we are playing India in Durban. They bat first and are reduced to 33 for three in the sixth over. We're buzzing. We're on our way. Rohit Sharma and MS Dhoni recover, but our eventual target of 154 in 20 overs seems within range.

Kingsmead is a cauldron of anticipation. Let's get this done. There are two routes for us to reach the last four: if we score 154 and win, we